support was Bob Woolmer.

I challenge anyone: go and check my batting stats during Bob's stint as Pakistan coach. You will notice that my performances were better in every aspect. That's because Bob never stopped me. In fact, he encouraged me to play my natural game. He never got in my way during regular matches, and before any big, crucial games, he'd tell me, 'Go play the way you want to play. Just destroy the other team and don't leave anything unsettled for tomorrow. No regrets.' Those were the only words I needed to hear. It was due to his coaching that I found my confidence, my groove again. My killer instinct with the blade returned somewhat.

But Bob was an outlier and, God bless his soul, we still miss him. As for the rest – coaches I've worked with, coaches I've never been able to work with – even though I'm very straightforward, I kept tolerating the wrong treatment from many of them only because I respected their position, if not them.

I must emphasize here that I don't think a good player necessarily makes for a good coach. Coaching is studied. There's a science to it. It's technical in nature and based on instruction and construction. At the international level, where skill sets are already so good, coaching is more about mental conditioning and keeping a player relaxed and confident, not just super fit and well-trained. So, to be a good coach, one needs to study and learn how to be one. You can't just show up and start coaching because you played for some major team and have several accolades to your name.

I may be wrong here but coaches also need to unlearn a lot of things to make sure that the team members, who may be a new generation of players, can play the game under optimal guidance. In any given situation, there is no formula for running a team or a unit. A father with six children cannot treat them all the same way. Every child has their own thing going on; some of them learn from love, and some of them learn from the stick. A good coach is like a good father – he has to treat his children according to the way they respond to change.

I remember Bob did something no other coach did for me or for the teams I played in. He made us perform based on our natural, organic potential. Being a cricketer is one thing. Being a coach is another. Being a selector is yet another. Bob had learnt the art of being a coach. He knew about my personality, what I was capable of. He knew how to get me going. Similarly, he knew how to motivate my teammates. Coaching at the international level is not about hand-holding or pampering or step-by-step guidance. I wasn't some kid fresh out of A-Levels. Whenever I was under pressure, Bob would remind me of who I really was and convince me that what I had done in the past, I was capable of repeating again.

Now that I think about it, I really wish Bob had been my coach from the beginning and given me the confidence to let me play my game. My performances could have been more consistent over the years. I may have become a much different player, maybe a different man altogether. But we lost him too soon.

With his passing during the 2007 World Cup, I went through the most challenging phase of my career. Being banned for the first couple of games – why on earth! – was bad enough. The loss to the West Indies in the opener and then to Ireland on St Patrick's Day – all causing our early exit from the tournament – was bad enough. And then, just like that, the night of the Ireland game, he was gone.

I have ghastly memories of the days that followed. The cops. The press. The hatred. The